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John Levy

John Levy is one of the few figures in jazz who has employed his musical prowess as a performer and a businessman. He was born in New Orleans on March 4, 1912 but grew up in Chicago when jazz was king. His boyhood friends included Milt Hinton and Ray Nance and he took up the violin at age eight, later moving to the bass. Early gigs included work with Earl Hines and Stuff Smith, who brought him to New York in 1943. He gained more experience with Don Byas, Errol Garner and Ben Webster, eventually becoming a member of the soon-to-be-famous George Shearing Quintet. John showed a talent for organization and eventually put performing aside to become Shearing's personal manager. His success in this field attracted other clients including Joe Williams and Nancy Wilson. Today John still acts as their manager and was recently presented with a gift of a new bass by his famous clients.

Mr. Levy was interviewed in the Caribbean aboard a cruise ship on May 31, 1995 by Monk Rowe.

MR: We are here today filming for the Hamilton Jazz Archive and we're going to get a little different slant today. We've been talking to a lot of musicians about their experiences in the jazz world in association with Count Basie and Joe Williams. Today we have John Levy with us, who is a longtime friend, associate and manager with Joe Williams and we're going to talk a little bit about how he looks at the music business. The business of music is something that sometimes musicians don't deal with as much as they should perhaps. And I would have to tell you that yesterday we had a long conversation between Milt Hinton and Joe Williams and they spoke very highly of you, and so I'd have to say you're doing something right over all these years.

JL: I think they're just real good friends. We've known each other for years. In fact one of the first playing engagements of Milt Hinton, uh, Milt Jackson, was in Philadelphia. He and I and Tal Farlow worked in Philadelphia. That was one of the first playing gigs for Milt, you know, and so that's how far back we go. We go back quite a way. And we were talking about that the other day, and I said, yeah, we go way, way back. And Joe I remember being a doorman at the Regal Theater and I used to go back stage and he worked part time as a doorman and then he would go and sing at night in a night club, you know. Well he has, I'm sure when you talk to him he had some great experiences to tell you.

MR: They had stories.

JL: They could talk for days.

MR: I know. It was very hard to stop after an hour. We'll do part two and three and four.

JL: Right.

MR: Tell us how you moved from — you're a musician yourself.

JL: Yeah. Well my story is all accidental I call it. I guess I was the type of person who was always interested in the business end of music, right from the very beginning. And I got into it sort of like, as I say accidental, because I had studied violin and then I sort of picked up bass, and Milt Hinton had sort of, we were in school together and Milt had sort of helped me develop that instrument. And I was actually working in the post office and just gigging on the side, because I got married very young so I had a family. And music I didn't figure was going to be the thing for me to —

MR: Don't quit your day gig, right?

JL: Yeah, that's the thing. Yeah that's something else. So we spent a lot of time, you know, learning about the inside of the business. For example at that time the musicians' union was very strong so you had to, in each city you went to play you had to report to the union and so I learned all about that part of the business. And by accident, here again I use the word accident, I was working in the post office and the president of the musicians' union, the Local 208 which was the black local in Chicago at the time, we're talking about all this happening in Chicago during that period. And he called me in and he said, "I've got a guy here, Stuff Smith, and we'll let him work in this city, but only if somebody like you can take charge and collect the money and handle the business," he says, "because Stuff is not reliable. He's a great jazz violinist and all that, but he's not a very reliable person." So I said, "fine." So I met Stuff and there was Raymond Walters was the piano player that had been chosen to work with Stuff. It was just a trio — violin, piano and bass. So we had this engagement downtown and they told me that there was an agent who booked Stuff, and his name was Joe Glaser, and that he was the booking person who was doing it but he couldn't come in to Chicago because they had a rap against him, or some kind of rap, because he'd been involved with gangsters. So —

MR: Wrong city to come to, right?

JL: Yeah. So he said, "you talk to this guy on the phone, and you know, you make sure you send him his commissions. And when you collect the money you pay off everybody and you send him his commissions." So that's how I got to know Joe Glaser, through this. And so right on time the commissions were sent and everything was taken care of. So I developed an excellent relationship with this top agent. He was one of the top agents.

MR: Was he doing Louis Armstrong at that time?

JL: Louis Armstrong, Dizzy, you name it. Especially trumpet players. He had Red Allen and Higginbotham and that group, the Dixieland groups. He had control over all of these different groups — Billie Holiday and you name it — Dinah Washington, he had all of these people. And so I got to know him first by just sending, make sure I sent that commission into him. So he sort of got a respect for me as a business person. So in 1944

we got a job to go to 52nd Street and open in the Onyx Club. And in those days they gave you a long term deal, so the deal was for six months. And Jimmy Jones, I'm sort of ahead of myself, because actually Jimmy Jones joined the group — Raymond Walters was the first pianist with us, and he worked with us maybe in Chicago for maybe about two or three months. And then Jimmy Jones and I had been friends, I knew him as a player and I recommended that he come on with us. And that's how the real Stuff Smith Trio got together. And then we came to New York and opened in the Onyx Club in August of 1944. And then I met Joe Glaser for the first time — this agent and everything. And as I said I developed an excellent relationship with him, and learned a lot about the inside of the business and how it all worked, which helped me later on when I finally went into that end of the business. We worked there at the Onyx Club — I guess we stayed there about a year. And I think I left, I was the first one to leave the trio. I went with Don Byas for a while, and then did a lot of recordings with Ink Spots and you name it, different jazz groups, and then Errol Garner. I made a series of records with Errol, just four sides actually, for Savoy Records with Errol Garner. And from that, one thing to the other until we get to 1948. In 1948 I got a call from Bobby Tucker to join him to work with Billie Holiday. And Billie Holiday had been in Lexington, Kentucky for a rehab for the dope. And she was coming out, and she was going to do a Carnegie Hall concert. And this was 1948. So we got together, and Denzel Best was the drummer. And we rehearsed out in New Jersey at Bobby Tucker's house, where Billie Holiday was staying. And rehearsed for that. And I can't remember the exact date in 1948 that we played Carnegie Hall, but we played it. It was my first time in Carnegie Hall. It was the first time that Carnegie Hall had ever had just a trio playing on stage, you know, so I mean the union made a ruling for the future that you'd have to have a minimum number of twelve musicians to play Carnegie Hall.

MR: No kidding?

JL: So anyway, we played the concert, did a double thing, two shows. And I stayed with Billie I guess maybe about, about a year. And we traveled. But I couldn't get along with her husband, who was the same name as mine, his name was John Levy. And we couldn't get along.

MR: Yeah. And was he managing her kind of?

JL: Yeah. He was managing her career, right. He was managing her career. Mismanaging her career.

MR: Yeah. You could see — you could probably see that it could be done a lot better.

JL: Oh, yeah, and that really ticked me off because everything was backwards, you know. We didn't get paid on time, and when you had to travel no arrangements were being made for it, and nothing. Everybody was on their own, you know, and I didn't like it. So

when they left to go to California, I decided I was going to quit. So I left that group and this was about the time that I was just sort of like floating around. I got a call to come down to Birdland to work, finish out a week with Buddy Rich. Buddy Rich had a big band. So I went down to Birdland and worked the week with Buddy Rich and George Shearing was playing opposite Buddy Rich. In other words, in those days, in Birdland, there might be three or four different acts. And in this case I think it was George Shearing with Buddy DeFranco and Denzel Best, and who else did he have with him — Margie Hyams I think was the other person that was with him. And this was that group that was playing there. So when my week ended with Buddy Rich, it was only for one week, George Shearing asked me would I join him for a couple of weeks until a bass player that he had that was working with him at the time, could come back. He had to leave because he had some problems and was going to take care of his mother or something, his mother was sick. To make a long story short, he never came back. And I ended up with George Shearing as the bass player in a permanent position. We recorded but the first thing we did we did some things on Discovery label and recorded some tunes and things on that, and then Buddy DeFranco had to leave because he was with MGM and George was with Capitol I think, no it wasn't Capitol it was MGM, it was the other way around. Buddy DeFranco went with Capitol and George was on MGM. So that's how we sort of split up. Buddy DeFranco got out of the group and they added Chuck Wayne and that was the beginning of the George Shearing Quintet — the original George Shearing Quintet — which was Denzel Best, Margie Hyams, Chuck Wayne, George Shearing and myself. And then we went on to record for MGM and from that on, "September Rain" and all that stuff, and George became about the hottest attraction in the business. And we were out there and I did all the business for him in other words. Joe Glaser was the agent, and so all the contacts and all the arrangements for everything was done through me. And yet I was just a bass player in there. So finally I said to George, "I can't do this and play every night." And we were working a lot of dates on percentage, and I said, "I have to go to the door, and run back and forth, and then come back and play the bass." So I says, "you've got to get somebody else." So he decided to make me, at that point it was Road Manager was what it was called. And Al McKibbon joined them in my place to play bass. And I became Road Manager. And from that, after maybe six months of that, we got someone else to do the Road Manager because the other business got so heavy, all the deals and everything that you had to be working with, I said I had to stay in New York more and work with the agent. Because George at that time, we're talking about '50 and '51, was about the hottest group in the country. We were the number one group. So there was a lot of business to handle. And that's how I got in to the business end of it. Completely in. From that day on I never played again.

MR: I would think that, you know, for managing musicians, you had a really valuable experience doing everything that they do, you know, because now you know what kind of travel they need to have, what kind of arrangements need to be made.

JL: Yeah. It was an excellent position to be in with George Shearing because they came from England and his wife had been handling everything. And they knew nothing about what was happening as far as the business end of it in this country. So it was a valuable experience for me to be able to be in that position but at the time I felt that, well this is just a job, you know, I didn't think any further than that, until we really got into it and George said to me, "we ought to form a company and, you know, since you're out here why don't you handle other people?" And other people were coming to me, to you know, to work with. So one of the first people was Teddi King, was a singer. George used her on one album I think on an MGM album she sang a couple of tracks on that album. It goes back so far I can't—

MR: Okay, well we won't date you with that.

JL: Remember it all, but anyway, that was my first person to sign up as a manager. And then I said, I was only thinking in terms of musicians anyway. I didn't know too much about singers and I didn't, you know that wasn't my cup of tea was the way I felt about it at that time. So we, I did sign up people like Ahmad Jamal, Ramsey Lewis, that was one of the first things. And by this time George Shearing was on Capitol Records by this time. And that's a whole other story, how we got on that. I just walked into the office in Capitol Records in California. We happened to be out there playing and I said, "we were on MGM but they didn't pick up our option and everything, and we'd like to sign with Capitol." They said, "fine." And that was how we signed. Just said okay. That was it. That was the deal. But anyway—

MR: This was early '50's?

JL: This is 50— has to be around '51. Yeah. That's about the time.

MR: And were you like aware of, I mean the big bands were still out there although it was —

JL: They were still out there but they were—

MR: It was after the war kind of —

JL: Yeah, they were kind of down. They were having a hard time, a very difficult time.

MR: And like what was the status—

JL: That was the time when Basie finally broke up and had the six pieces, you know, because it was really rough out there for big bands. But groups like George was really hot, and Dave Brubeck, and that was the hottest things going, playing the colleges and you know, so it was really — the big band it just cost too much to travel. And the economics of it at that time was even worse than they are now. I mean they're bad enough now, but for a big band it was terrible, you know. But anyway, that's how I got into that end of the

business. And then one by one different people came along. And I knew Joe, for years I'd known Joe Williams. And when he left the Basie band and he called me one day he said, "come and take this telephone out of my hands."

MR: That's it, yeah.

JL: And that was it. No contract. No nothing. And the other people I guess came along through the record companies. In those days, especially Capitol Records, almost anybody who was anybody that came through the label that didn't have management I'd get a call and they'd say — in jazz that is, you know — "do you want to manage this person?" Or they'd recommend me, you know. And that way I remember Dakota Staton was one. She was on Capitol Records and Dave Cavanaugh, who was the A&R man for George Shearing and later on for Cannonball and everybody. So a lot of the people that I had at that time was on the Capitol label. Nancy Wilson came along through that. Through Cannonball I met Nancy, and it just went from one to the other. And all of a sudden I found myself—

MR: Somebody take the phone out of your hands—

JL: Yeah. I needed somebody to take the phone, that's right, that's right. So it was building and all of a sudden I'm managing ten or twelve people, which is not, doesn't make sense, because you can not do the job. I learned that quickly, you know, having that many people just wasn't, didn't make sense. I had a lot of help, I had different people working with me, but everybody depended on me for the decisions and they wanted to talk to me about anything. They wanted to talk to the Road Managers and everything. My son was working with me as a Road Manager. He went out with Ramsey for a while, then he was out with Wes Montgomery, and he was out with Stanley Turrentine, and Freddie Hubbard, and you know, so this was a time I had all these people. So I guess this is we're talking now in the 70's. And then I got sick, and I had, I was diagnosed as having prostate cancer. But it was in the very, very, very early stages, and I had an excellent doctor and that cleared that up. In other words I haven't had any problems for me since then.

MR: That's fantastic.

JL: Although once a year I go and make sure — a check-up and all that. But it worked out fine for me. I was very fortunate. I had one of the top specialists in that field at the time. And then I decided this is too much pressure, all these people and I sort of cut back on it, and finally down to maybe three or four people. And now, at this point, two people which is Nancy Wilson and Joe Williams, and Henry Johnson, I work with because he's with Joe and anything I can do to work with him is fine, and we're very close. But that's pretty much the story as far as —

MR: That's great. When you first started working with Joe then, he had come out of that period where he'd had the hit with the Basie band. Was there a conscious decision with you guys at that point where you said okay, I did the big band thing, now I'm ready for a solo career, or did you find a group to play with him or was he kind of freelancing with different bands?

JL: No, no, no, no, no. He went right into, went pretty much right into a group thing, you know. I think it was Junior Mance was one of the first pianists, and then later on he had several different pianists, I can't recall exactly in what order and who was there. Joe probably told you that story. But it was a conscious effort to put together a group but it was like a small jazz group, because that was what was the popular thing at the time. So I remember Sweets Edison was in the group, and there's a tenor player, I can't recall his name was in the group for a while with us. And we used different people, you know. And finally after several years of mixtures of different musicians and everything, he settled pretty much on a standard trio thing, along with maybe adding a guitar here and there or adding a horn here and there. And you know, used as the basis for his, which is still the system. But still, when the Basie band was still on the road and going, he had to do a lot of things, at least there was a lot of offers, because the relationship was excellent with Basie. So there was a lot of times where you know they'd make offers to us, the agencies would make offers for us to join the Basie band for a special or a festival.

MR: They're still doing it right?

JL: So we kept working with the Basie band and that exists until today. We still work maybe two and three and sometimes as many as four different times a year with the Basie band. And what we do then, we just take his own, Norman Simmons, his pianist, and then work within the context of the Basie band. And we do quite a few of those things. In fact we're going to be going to play the Montreal festival this year, Toronto festival this year, back to back with the Basie band. And we've got an offer on the table now to go to Poland with the Basie band, and I'll know when I get back. Because I don't want to know about any business when I'm on this —

MR: That's a major project I guess.

JL: Yeah. So I'll have to tackle that when I get back. And I learned a lot of things, a lot about the system by working, by my experiences with George Shearing at the beginning and traveling in Europe and Japan and all of that. You've got to know all of the different promoters all over the world and you've got to know the system, how you go about getting in and out of countries. And Wes Montgomery tells a story about, I wasn't with them and he went to Spain. And he got off the plane and the guy said to him, "you a guitar player?" He said, "yeah." So he said they took the guitar out and looked in it and looked in the case and everything. And they had these dogs sniffing for dope. And he was

there and the guy said to him, the head of customs, he said, "so you're supposed to be able to play this thing, now play something." So he says, "you know it has to be hooked up." He tried to explain to the guy. The guy said "play." And so he had to take the guitar out and play something to show that he—

MR: Ruth Brown told us a similar story but it was in the south with a policeman on the side of the road.

JL: Oh yeah. They had— the musicians had some great experiences with that kind of system in the south and what would happen to you in that instance you know.

MR: When you started with Joe, as far as his place in the marketplace for records, was he billed as strictly as jazz singer? Was he a, you know, a blues singer? What was his—

JL: Pretty much a jazz singer.

MR: Yeah?

JL: Yeah. He was booked as a jazz and blues, and that was it. And nobody realized or knew, his ability to sing, except people in Chicago who knew him years before. Because Joe used to sing in a night club where you didn't even see him. The girls walked out and —

MR: You'd hear this voice?

JL: Yeah. All you could hear was his voice, and you know, he'd sing like "A Pretty Girl Is Like a Melody," and these girls would walk around. And you never saw him. And he'd go on the air, like I think he was with Jimmy Noone. And he'd go on the air and sing nothing but ballads you know, just nothing but pretty tunes. But nobody paid any attention to that. A recording company didn't want to know about that. They didn't want to record Joe doing any ballads or anything. Right up until the last few years, we had to fight in order to really get them to allow Joe to sing a ballad. "Here's to Life" we had that tune for years before Shirley Horn recorded it and we'd been trying to get to record it and they would not, nobody wants it, "no, that's not Joe." You know, "that's not Joe." You know it's a pretty tune and all that. And I insisted on a full orchestra, too, that's the next thing. And nobody wanted to come up with that full orchestra. "Oh it costs too much, you know, why don't Joe just sing the blues and get a little group together and that's it." And I had to fight. And in fact I quit Polygram for that reason, just walked out, said forget it, you know. Are we going to do this? This is the next project or no project at all. That was it. And finally Telarc agreed to do it. And but we still had to do a Basie album with Basie first. And then we got the deal to go to London and got Quantum to do the Telarc, the full strings and everything, the album that we wanted to do and had been fighting to do for years. The next thing we had been trying to do over the years was a spiritual album. He finally got that off of Telarc. So it's been a good thing with them because they've allowed him to do what he wanted to do for years and couldn't get on. We'd been trying, you know, every record company he's been with, he had been trying to do these things.

Because when he started out, actually RCA Victor did do some really beautiful things with big bands and strings and things. They never did anything with the records, but you know, this was the era of "A Man Ain't Supposed To Cry" I think, and some of those things that they did in those days. But they never did anything with them. Because they were pretty ballad things, and they didn't know how to promote them, they just satisfied Joe, you know.

MR: That's funny, because you know you read about the rock 'N roll bands, and they have the same problems you know. They're dissatisfied with their record companies because, you know, "well we've done these albums for you now we want to do this new type of thing." And the record company says, "no, stay with this sound."

JL: Yeah. They want to stay with the tried and true, what they can sell easily.

MR: I wonder if they do that with classical musicians. "Don't record any Schubert, stick with the Mozart."

JL: They probably do. I don't know. But that's probably the situation with them too. Because they want to put you in a groove, in a certain category. And that goes with everything, with singers and musicians. You're in a certain category and you can't do anything different. They want you to stay right in that groove that they've got you locked into. And it's difficult to break out. You almost have to be in a position where you say I'm not going to do another thing until I do what I want to do on this. Because no matter what your contract is. I learned that a long time ago. The contract deals and the record deals with the companies. It depends on what you're selling. I don't care what it says, if you're selling records and you're making money for the company then you can do anything you want to do you know. You can make your own deal no matter what your contract is. But if it's just an ordinary thing, they you have to go along with what they think is best. And today's market is terrible because the people who are in the record business who are the people who make the decisions, they have no concept of the music or what's happening. All they want to know about is, as they say, the bottom line. And they're looking for young people with no experience or very little experience, and they'll put the money behind them to make something happen for them, and then after that they'll get another batch.

MR: As long as they as they can tell them what to do you mean?

JL: Oh, yeah. They tell you exactly what to do. That's what they want. And managers like myself, they don't exist today with the upcoming people, because in most cases they are lawyers or accountants that do the managing. And they have no idea of what it's about, but there's so much legal stuff going on, as I call it "legalistic" — the legalese of the business, the way —

MR: Is it getting harder?

JL: Oh, yeah, yeah. Oh yeah. A person like myself who is not a lawyer, and I know about contracts, I know enough about it, I've been it long enough that I can draft one and I know exactly what's happening with it. But they won't accept that. You have to be a lawyer. Because you can, the record company can be sued if the artist signs with them without having a lawyer represent them. So it's gotten to that point, where, like everything else in this country, anything you do, you have to have a lawyer almost to do it. It's like we make agreements say to do something like this for the school, and it gets to the point where this is unusual, just that you've got a simple form to sign.

MR: Right. It's only a one-pager.

JL: Yes, one page, simple form to sign. Because normally oh, it's just pages. I have a contract, a Nancy Wilson contract that has 40 pages on it, for Columbia Records. Forty pages. And it's, it gives you one thing on page five and takes it away on page nine.

MR: And then it's got something right at the end that says "if we forgot to say anything in this contract" you know—don't forget about that.

JL: They've got it worded, and you've got to go through all of that stuff today. And it makes it a little difficult. But—

MR: Can I wind you back for a minute?

JL: Yeah, sure.

MR: You said going back to Chicago. And you talked about the musician's union and you said there was a black musician's union. This was separate?

JL: Oh, yes.

MR: And how, when did that like stop?

JL: I don't know the exact year. But I guess it stopped in the 60's.

MR: Wow, that long.

JL: Where they dissolved the black unions into the, for example in Chicago it was Local 10. And Local 10 took over 208 and I think a couple of the executives in 208 became, you know, because part of Local 10's hierarchy in other words, the people that took care of the business of the union. And in California, 47 was the major union and I'm trying to remember what number the black union was, but anyway they all integrated. Like it was a whole period of when all this integration started up in the schools and the whole thing, around that time.

MR: What was scale like back then?

JL: Oh, jeez.

MR: I mean Milt and Joe were talking about that.

JL: Yeah, they probably remember better than I do what it was. But it wasn't much I'll tell you that.

MR: I remember Milt I think was saying that before he joined Cab he was working for $35 a week, and you know then he went with Cab and it tripled and he said, "I'm a millionaire."

JL: Well I know I worked, I worked in night clubs in Chicago coming along and made $50 a week, and that was, that was big money, you know? It wasn't big money, it was just enough to get by on, but my first experience of really making money was really with George Shearing because up to that point, even with Buddy Rich and with the Stuff Smith things was pretty good, but the real money, the real money came with — for me — came with George Shearing, and then of course the experience and all that. But I was fortunate, yeah, as I say, very, very, very lucky in my relationships with the playing days. Because from, I was always with the very best people, you know. It was always, whatever the dollar was it was top dollar. And I was very independent and I didn't travel much. My move from Chicago to New York was the biggest move and I never went back. I moved my family and everything to New York. And after I'd been there for a while and I realized I wasn't going to go back to Chicago to live. And I worked all the time, from one group to the next and the next, and just until I got into this end of the business. And a lot of people ask me, "don't you miss playing?" I say I did at the beginning. I used to go around and sort of really miss it, and sit in whenever I could. And I did that for maybe two or three years after. Then I got so busy I didn't have time to do that, and didn't even own a bass. And for my 75th birthday, Nancy and Joe got together and had got a bass for me. They gave me that as a birthday present.

MR: Wow.

JL: Maybe they were trying to tell me something.

MR: Just in case you don't have a job as a manager any time soon, maybe you'll need this, huh?

JL: Maybe they was trying to tell me, "you better go back to this."

MR: I think the musicians must have always thought of you as being on their side, you know?

JL: That's right. And I was always on their side, I still am.

MR: Yeah. That's good.

JL: Oh, yeah. When it comes down to negotiations and anything about money, well what about the musicians? And you know, we're talking about a tour next year with Nancy and Joe, and, for Columbia Artists. And they were talking about, the people at Columbia Artists were talking about, "well, the side men, what do you want to, how do you want to work that?" You know, okay, we know what Nancy gets, we know what Joe gets, the group that's going to work with them together and we worked all the details of that out, who's going to play for who, and we won't carry a lot of musicians and everything, we'll carry a small group. And it got down to the point of what the musicians are going to get

paid. So the first couple of figures they brought us I said, "oh, na, na, na, na, na." They have to get more than that. And they have to get certain conditions and certain things for them. So it's always been — because I still feel like a musician.

MR: Would I work for that, right?

JL: Yeah, no, no I wouldn't do it for that. And the conditions you know? Like for example a lot of times when a deal is made for you to travel to Europe or to Japan they'll say, "okay, Joe can go first class, he and his wife will travel first class, but the musicians, they have to travel coach." I says, "no. They're going to Europe." I says, "you know they're in a plane for eight or ten hours," or, "you're going all the way to Japan that's ten or twelve hours. Na, na, na, na, na, na" I say. They either go first class, or at least business class, at least where they've got a decent seat and they're not cramped up together to travel these long distances. Now other than that there's no deal. And that's the way it is. It's no deal. And they respect you for it. They say okay. If they want the artist, they'll buy it.

MR: Was that harder for you to do in the beginning? To say no, no, no? Or were you always—

JL: No. It didn't bother me to say no in a minute, you know. A lot of times, because Joe is very easy going. And he'd say, well you know. But I'd say, no, I don't want to do that. See but if you insist, you know, if you really want to do it. But this is the deal, if you really want to go on and do it. And a lot of times he'll say, well I'll go on, you know. We had a lot of offers to play with different college jazz bands all around the country. So that would mean just Joe and Norman would come in. And they would say this is the price or the conditions and everything, or, "we're just a school starting out" or, "we have this band and we're trying to raise money to keep it going" and all that nonsense. And I say, "yeah that's nice," I say, "but we've got to get this."

MR: Right. We're making a living here.

JL: Yeah. It doesn't make any difference to me. And Joe would say, "yeah, we'll go on and play it." But now more and more he's getting away from that, because, "it takes too much of my time. I have to go there, I have to rehearse with these guys, and take up the time, and as much as I like to try to help these schools and all that, I can't do it anymore." It's too much. Joe's 75 now you know. That's—

MR: Right. You've got to pick and choose.

JL: Oh, you do, you do. And I, you know, really pick and choose the things that are most important for his career and for him, and the things he enjoys doing. It's like these cruises. He enjoys cruises. Because he gets with the people and he mingles, he's very open, and he enjoys being around people. But I turned down several other cruises, you know I've turned them down. I only pick the best ones, and go out on that and everything. And he talks about your school — he loves Hamilton. And I think he was there for George Shearing.

MR: Yes, he was. And we just did Clark Terry.

JL: Yeah, Clark Terry, yeah. And he told me, "leave that time open — I'm going there — they're going to give a doctorate to George" or, "they're going to give a doctorate to Clark." And he's been trying to get me to come with him. He wanted me to come this last time.

MR: You should come, it's nice there.

JL: Oh, I don't want to travel.

MR: Oh, it's right up the Thruway from you, you know.

JL: Yes, I know.

MR: Well we'll get you up there.

JL: But anyway, sooner or later I'll go with him. Because there's two things that he has blocked out every year, and that's the Kennedy Center and the Kennedy Honors in December and your school, that period of time — those two things.

MR: We're in good company then.

JL: "I don't work during that period" he says. And that's the way it goes, yeah.

MR: Yeah, that's interesting. You know I guess you can go to college now and you can take the business of music, you know?

JL: Yeah, that's a good thing. Because they no longer do, like when Milt and I came along, in high school, there was like it is in college now. I mean they had these bands and every high school had a band in Chicago and I remember the professor who taught music in Phillips High School where Milt went. It was just perfect. You'd walk in and you'd get private lessons from him plus rehearsing, you know playing with the band and everything, and it developed some great musicians. And a lot of them would walk in and didn't even have instruments to play. You'd come along and the kid, what they would do, they'd ask you, "what do you want to play?" And if there was an instrument left that you wanted to play, most of the time the trumpets and the saxophones would go first, and there'd only be so many of those. And nobody wanted the violins or that kind of stuff. Most of them wanted the horns, and guitar was, forget about that there was no such thing. I remember John Collins, the banjo [guitar] player, started out playing banjo. But anyway, they had instruments for the kids. And they had a certain number of instruments and you'd use it the whole time that you were in the school, the four years that you were there you'd have this instrument to play and learn on and everything, and practice, and take it home and all that. But all that's gone. You don't reach that now until you get to the college stage. There are some high school bands around the country, but not too many.

MR: Well a lot of the people we've talked to have talked about their great high school experience and it's amazing the congregation of people that were in Chicago for instance, the famous names that all came out of there in that time period.

JL: It was great. And that was the period when most of them came out. Because they had that music education. It was a part of the training that you got. You had to have that. Everybody had to have a certain amount of music. Everybody, in all the classes, no matter what your majors were, you had to have a music class. They called it music appreciation, where they'd play records of the, you know, the classical records, and you had to identify who wrote this, whether it was Bach or Beethoven or whoever, you know, was the composer. And you got to learn a lot about the general culture of music. And it was a great experience in those days. And it's unfortunate that these youngsters now, who need it, to me, more than ever, they really need this. They don't get it.

MR: Yeah. If you were able to tell some future jazz star a couple words about what they should know about their own business. Do you have any thoughts on that?

JL: Well, today I would tell any youngsters starting out, the most important thing is to try to get some experience with older players or people who've been out there. Because what's happening now is a lot of youngsters are coming into the business and they make the records and the records sold, and they're hot records. But they don't have any experience about playing with anybody, you know they don't have the experience. And they don't really have a style. For example, when I came along, you could recognize the person by the style, how they played, the style. Today these kids, you hear them and I don't know one from the other. I listen to them and I say who is this and who is this? They don't have any set style, because they haven't learned the experience. They can play, and they play with feeling and they can read better than a lot of musicians that came along during my time, but they don't have any experience of playing with anybody. So they don't get themselves any style and are able to listen to what these people before them. I guess Wynton and his brother and a few others that came along, they'd listen because of their parents saying, "look, this is where the roots are of this whole thing, so you've got to learn this first before you get to where you are when you get to Coltrane and Miles and all those people" — there's a lot of folks came before that.

MR: I suppose it would depend on what their parents were listening to.

JL: That's right. It has a lot to do with that, it has a lot to do with that. And as far as the business is concerned, I would tell them most of all please watch your lawyers and your accountant, because they're ripping these kids off something awful, you know, it's terrible. And take care of, make sure your own money is, don't listen to anybody else. Sign your own checks. Make sure that you take care of your own, that end of the business. Unless you have someone very close to you who you can really trust. Because

they'll rip you off. And the way it's going down now they get ripped off very easily. Guys make a lot of money real fast now and it's gone real quick.

MR: Well, this has been a fascinating discussion. We've been talking with John Levy, who has seen the music business from a lot of different angles here, and it's really been great talking to you.

JL: Well it's been a pleasure, truly, it's really been a pleasure, Monk, to really sit and talk about it. I just wish I could have prepared a little better.

MR: Well, you had some great thoughts.

JL: Yeah, a little preparation, but you called me kind of sudden and I said — oh, what are we going to talk about? I've got to get all my facts together here. Because this year I'm 83 years old, so, you know you don't remember things so well, you know.

MR: Congratulations.

JL: It kind of catches up with you, and people say to me, "why are you still doing this — why don't you retire?" I say, "retire to what? What am I going to retire to? This is the greatest life in the world."

MR: Yeah, you tell them, you see this, you know where I was when I did this video? So don't tell me about working too hard.

JL: That's right. That's absolutely right. So I really you know, enjoy it. I enjoy the business and I enjoy the music part of it. And I wouldn't know what to do with myself to retire. I recently moved to Las Vegas and everybody says "why did you go to Las Vegas" you know. I say, "well, for several reasons," I say, "one of them was taxes, the other one was earthquakes," and so—

MR: And you can play golf with Joe.

JL: Yeah. I can play golf with Joe. I'm close to Joe and now Nancy bought a condominium there, so I says so I've got my clients right there with me. You know we all enjoy the Las Vegas weather and just taking it easy. You know we're at that stage where we sort of coast on it a little bit, and we're not out there fighting it every day. So it's enjoyable. I enjoy it very much. And it's been a pleasure doing this. And I make a point — I'm coming next time. I want to come to your school next time.

MR: All right. Great. We'll see you at Hamilton College. And as part of our Jazz Archive, it's been a real pleasure to talk to John Levy today. Thank you very much.

JL: Thank you.